

DIFFERENT STROKES: NAVINA AND ARCHIT MANMOHAN



SUVASHIS MULLICK

"I came across her profile, initiated a contact and it was accepted the very next day."

HE IS: A Marwari, working as a channel manager of an IT company

SHE IS: A Punjabi, working with an MNC bank

SOUGHT: Decent, educated and understanding life partner

WEDDED: July 17, 2007, outside the community and did not care for horoscopes

PARENTS: Accepted their choice and were in the loop throughout

THE STORY: It took them a month to graduate from the Net to phone calls. They sought parental blessings. Both sets of parents gladly accepted the match. It didn't matter that they came from different backgrounds. They met and got engaged on the same day. She is now working with ABN-Amro Bank in Kolkata.

60% Want partners from outside their community or city

are asserting personal choice," sums up Anupam Mittal, CMD, People Group, the company that owns shaadi.com. "They are dictating terms in finding partners who suit their goals and ambitions."

New technology supports the blueprint of change. "The Internet brings limitless possibilities," points out Mittal. "It allows you to meet a huge number of people, affords anonymity, brings down barriers like caste, puts men and women on an equal footing and doesn't carry any of the ignominies of the old system." It also does away with distance and geographical boundaries. For Clinton Goveas, 31, it was instant synergy on cyberspace. He works with an online gaming portal in Mumbai and had been surfing social-networking sites since 1995 in the hope of meeting like-minded friends and, hopefully, a life-partner. He found his dream-mate, living 3,000 miles away. "We clicked instantly," he says. After weeks of emails, they informed the parents about their choice.

"Something transformative is happening on the arranged marriage front," says Shelja Sen, consultant psychologist and couple therapist with Sitaram Bhartia Institute of Science and Research, Delhi. "Indian youth seem to be in a mood to take risks." She adds that parents, at times, understand and encourage, but often they are sceptical and censorious. "But the youth are not necessarily seeking parental green signal. They are telling the parents about their need to direct and lead the most important phase of their lives." Sen marvels at the level of "openness" among the young people who come to her: "There's a sea-change regarding age, looks, money and attitude." She witnesses high-earning women pitching for men with modest incomes; younger men opting for older, divorced women with children. She also finds a total irreverence for traditional "good looks".

For parents, the transformation is remarkable, if not traumatic. The year

was 1967. Her parents had put in an ad in a popular daily: "Wanted suitable match for a beautiful, convent-educated, virgin, homely, accomplished, Kayastha girl, 20, from a respectable family. Boy, around 28, should be in good health, from same caste and well-established family. Decent marriage." They found the suitable boy and 30 years down the line, she is now checking out the marriage market for her 27-year-old daughter, just back from a study stint in the US. But she has no clue that her daughter nurses a broken heart, despairs over her parents' groom-hunt and badly misses the brave new world of exploration and experience she has left behind. Nor does she know that her daughter has enrolled herself in a marriage portal, hoping to outsmart the parents and find a "soul-mate" on her own.

In contrast, Ishani Ghose's aunts let out a symphony of sighs whenever they talk of "girls today". Yes, she is pretty, has a string of fancy degrees and

64% men in Delhi are open to intercaste marriage, only 24% in Chennai